

Self-Portrait Writing Guide

A Step-by-Step Approach to Your Literary Self-Portrait

Before You Begin: Pre-Writing Strategies

Brainstorming Techniques

- Mind Mapping: Put “ME” in the center, create branches for traits, goals, and language skills.
- List Making: Set a timer for three minutes per category and write everything that comes to mind.
- Question Storming: Ask yourself “What if?” and “Why?” questions about your choices.
- Story Mining: Think of specific moments that reveal who you are.

Reflection Warm-Up

Complete these sentence stems to get your thoughts flowing:

- Right now, I am someone who...
- In five years, I hope to be someone who...
- When I face challenges, I usually...
- My biggest strength as a student is...

Category 1: Traits You Aspire to Develop

Getting Started: Trait Selection

Step 1: Explore the Possibilities

Choose from traits like resilience, empathy, courage, discipline, curiosity, patience, leadership, authenticity, creativity, perseverance, kindness, confidence, integrity, adaptability, mindfulness.

Step 2: Personal Connection Check

For each trait you’re considering, ask:

- Why does this matter to me specifically?

- What experiences have shown me I need this trait?
- Who do I know that embodies this trait well?

Sentence Starters for Trait Development

Introducing Your Trait

- One trait I hope to cultivate is ____ because...
- I've realized that I need to develop ____ after...
- ____ is a quality I admire in others, especially when...
- Historically, I've struggled with ____, but I want to change that because...

Explaining Why It Matters

- This trait is important to me because...
- I've seen how ____ can make a difference when...
- Without ____, I tend to...
- Developing ____ would help me...

Providing Evidence/Examples

- For example, last year when...
- I remember a time when my lack of ____ caused...
- I've noticed that people who have ____ are able to...
- This became clear to me during...

Organizational Strategy for Traits Section

1. Hook: Start with a story or observation that shows why this trait matters.
2. Definition: Explain what this trait means to you personally.

3. Evidence: Give a specific example from your life.
 4. Vision: Describe how developing this trait will change you.
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Category 2: Priorities, Goals & Vision

Understanding the Vocabulary

- Priority: What matters most to you right now.
- Intention: What you hope for or value.
- Goal: A specific, measurable outcome you want to reach.
- Plan: The concrete steps you'll take to reach your goal.
- Strategy: Your approach, mindset, or methods for success.

Goal-Setting Framework: SMART-ER Goals

- Specific: Exactly what do you want to achieve?
- Measurable: How will you know you've succeeded?
- Achievable: Is this realistic for you right now?
- Relevant: Does this connect to your bigger priorities?
- Time-bound: When do you want to accomplish this?
- Evaluate: How will you check your progress?
- Readjust: How will you adapt if things change?

Sentence Starters for Goals & Priorities

Identifying Your Priorities

- Right now, what matters most to me is...

- My biggest priority this year is...
- I've decided to focus on ____ because...
- When I think about my future, I most want to...

Setting Specific Goals

- A concrete goal I've set for myself is...
- By ____ (date), I plan to...
- I'm working toward...
- One thing I'm determined to accomplish is...

Describing Your Plan

- My strategy for reaching this goal includes...
- The steps I'm taking are...
- I've broken this down by...
- To stay on track, I plan to...

Addressing Challenges

- The biggest obstacle I anticipate is...
- When things get difficult, I will...
- I've learned from past experience that...
- To overcome ____, I need to...

Organizational Strategy for Goals Section

1. Vision Statement: Paint a picture of your ideal future.
2. Current Priority: What you're focusing on right now.

3. Action Plan: Specific steps you're taking.
 4. Problem-Solving: How you'll handle obstacles.
 5. Progress Check: How you'll know you're succeeding.
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Category 3: Reader, Writer, Thinker

Self-Assessment Questions

As a Reader

- What happens when you encounter difficult text?
- What types of reading do you enjoy most or least?
- How do you make sense of confusing information?
- What reading strategies work best for you?

As a Writer

- When do you write your best work?
- What part of the writing process is easiest or hardest?
- How do you organize your thoughts before writing?
- What feedback has helped you improve?

As a Thinker

- How do you approach complex problems?
- What helps you think more clearly?
- How do you handle disagreement or conflicting ideas?
- When do you feel most intellectually engaged?

Sentence Starters for Reader/Writer Identity

Reading Strategies

- When I read something confusing, I usually...
- I understand text better when I...
- My biggest reading challenge is...
- I've learned that good readers...

Writing Process

- I write best when...
- To organize my thoughts, I...
- My writing improves when I...
- The hardest part of writing for me is...

Critical Thinking

- When I encounter a complex problem, I...
- I've learned that language can be used to...
- To understand different perspectives, I...
- I think most clearly when...

Growth and Goals

- This year, I want to improve my ability to...
- I've noticed that I'm getting better at...
- A skill I'm still developing is...
- By the end of this course, I hope to...

Organizational Strategy for Reader/Writer Section

1. Current State: Honestly assess where you are now.
 2. Strengths: What you already do well.
 3. Growth Areas: What you're working to improve.
 4. Strategies: Specific techniques that help you.
 5. Future Vision: How you want to develop these skills.
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Revision and Polish Strategies

First Draft to Final Draft

Round 1: Big Picture Revision

- Does each section connect to the others?
- Is your voice authentic throughout?
- Have you provided specific examples?
- Does the ending tie everything together?

Round 2: Paragraph-Level Revision

- Does each paragraph have a clear focus?
- Are your transitions smooth?
- Have you varied your sentence structure?
- Is your evidence compelling?

Round 3: Sentence-Level Editing

- Are there any unclear or awkward sentences?
- Have you eliminated unnecessary words?

- Is your grammar and punctuation correct?
- Does your word choice reflect your personality?

Peer Review Questions

- What's the strongest part of this self-portrait?
- Where do you want to know more about the writer?
- Which trait or goal seems most important to them? Why?
- What questions do you still have after reading?

Final Check: Voice and Authenticity

- Does this sound like you?
- Would someone who knows you recognize your personality?
- Are you being honest about both strengths and areas for growth?
- Does your writing show genuine reflection rather than surface thoughts?

Quick Tips for Success

1. Be specific: Instead of "I want to be successful," try "I want to earn a scholarship to study marine biology."
2. Use stories: Personal anecdotes make your writing memorable and authentic.
3. Show growth: Acknowledge where you've been, where you are, and where you're going.
4. Connect the dots: Help readers see how your traits, goals, and academic identity work together.
5. Stay honest: Authentic struggles are more compelling than fake perfection